Lessons from the Mentoring Initiative

Implications for AWSNA Institutes

Purpose of This Report

In 2024, 2025 and 2026 The Center for Anthroposophy offered the Mentoring Course, a program that developed out of AWSNA Teacher Life Cycle (TLC) research and Taskforce work. The mentoring initiative was developed to provide renewed training and support for experienced Waldorf educators undertaking mentoring work. The AWSNA TLC work focused on gathering input from Waldorf schools, including approximately 100 interviews, and from a recognition that the needs of schools and teachers had changed considerably since earlier mentor training initiatives were developed.

This report brings together two sources of learning from the initiative: reflections from Karen Atkinson on the design, facilitation, and evolution of the program, and follow-up survey responses from participants in the 2024 and 2025 cohort after they had an opportunity to put their learning into practice.

The survey is particularly valuable because it moves the evaluation beyond participants' immediate experience of the course. Respondents reflected on how they had actually mentored during the following academic year, whom they had supported, which approaches they had used, and what additional support they needed.

The purpose of this report is not to provide a mentoring program for other institutes to replicate. Rather, it identifies learning that may be transferable to mentoring, leadership, teacher development, and other professional learning initiatives across Waldorf teacher education institutes.

Evidence of Impact

The follow-up survey provides encouraging evidence that the training translated into practice.

Participants reported increased confidence and clarity in their mentoring. Some described the course as affirming experience and capacities they already possessed while providing frameworks that allowed them to use those capacities more intentionally. The monthly rhythm and integration of pedagogical and artistic content were also identified as important in keeping participants engaged and reflective throughout the program.

Participants also reported using specific tools and frameworks from the training in their mentoring work. Frameworks introduced during the course became organizing structures for some mentors, while others incorporated artistic activities and documentation strategies. The survey therefore suggests that the program provided not only inspiration but practical approaches that participants could adapt to their own settings.

The work reached beyond beginning teachers. Participants mentored new and untrained teachers, experienced Waldorf teachers, educators moving into new roles, special subject teachers, and pedagogical

administrators across a variety of school settings. Most respondents reported feeling either well or very well prepared to undertake mentoring in their schools.

At the same time, both the interview and survey point toward important lessons about what is needed for professional learning to have sustained impact. These lessons extend beyond mentoring and have implications for professional development programs more broadly.

Seven Key Lessons for Professional Development Institutes

1. Design from Current Needs—and Continue Learning from Participants

The mentoring initiative began with listening. Its development was informed by extensive research with schools and by a desire to respond to the needs of experienced teachers in the current Waldorf educational landscape rather than simply reproducing an earlier mentoring model.

That responsiveness continued after implementation began. Karen described adjusting aspects of the program as she learned from successive cohorts and as conditions within schools continued to change.

The participant survey demonstrates the value of continuing that inquiry after a program ends. It provided information that could not have been gathered simply through end-of-course evaluations: what participants actually did with their training, what proved useful in practice, what difficulties emerged, and what support they wanted next.

Learning for institutes: Program evaluation should be understood as part of program design rather than something that happens only at the end. Institutes can benefit from gathering information before a program begins, listening during implementation, and returning to participants after they have had time to apply their learning.

This creates a cycle of inquiry → program design → implementation → application → reflection → redesign.

2. Create a Sustained Learning Journey, Not a Series of Sessions

One of the clearest findings across both the interview and survey concerns the rhythm of the program.

Monthly online sessions provided continuity while giving participants time between meetings to process, practice, and integrate what they were learning. The survey confirms that participants valued this structure. Respondents specifically identified the monthly meetings and pedagogical content as helping them remain present and reflective in their mentoring work.

The in-person residency served a different purpose. It provided opportunities for intensive learning, artistic work, relationship building, and immersion in a wider professional community.

Experience also helped clarify which activities belonged in which setting. Visual artistic activities could work reasonably well online, while eurythmy and other activities dependent upon shared physical presence were considerably more successful in person.

The content itself combined best practices and practical guidance with anthroposophical and pedagogical foundations. The survey indicates that participants were able to translate this combination into action, adapting specific frameworks, artistic practices, and documentation approaches to their own mentoring.

Learning for institutes: Design the entire learning journey rather than simply determining the content of individual sessions. Consider what requires sustained engagement over time; what can be done effectively online; what genuinely benefits from physical presence; when participants need time to practice and reflect; and how foundational ideas will connect to practical tools. Hybrid learning is most effective when it is an intentional design choice rather than simply a way of reducing the number of in-person sessions.

3. Make Cohort, Relationship, and Community Part of the Learning

The cohort became an important element of the mentoring program rather than simply the group of people receiving the training.

The in-person residency deepened those relationships, particularly because the mentoring cohort was embedded within a larger summer learning community. Participants could retain the intimacy of their own group while joining others for keynotes, singing, lectures, meals, artistic experiences, and social events.

Karen's reflections emphasized how much important connection happened outside formal teaching sessions—in meals, breaks, and informal conversations. She also learned that participants valued her continued presence during the residency even when other instructors were teaching. They experienced the primary facilitator as the thread connecting the different parts of the program.

The survey strongly reinforces the importance of community. Participants asked for continued opportunities to meet with their cohort, including in-person gatherings, reflective spaces, artistic work, and continued mentoring support. One respondent described the cohort as a "true mentorship family."

Learning for institutes: Relationships and community should be treated as part of the educational design. Sustained cohorts, consistent facilitation, informal time, connection to a wider professional community, and structures for continued peer connection can all contribute to the learning. The survey suggests that community is not merely something that makes a program enjoyable; it can become one of the resources participants carry forward into their professional lives.

4. Design for Application—and for the School Conditions That Make Application Possible

The follow-up survey provides clear evidence that participants used their learning. They incorporated mentoring frameworks, documentation approaches, and artistic practices into their work.

Their mentoring also took many forms. Participants reported one-to-one mentoring, peer mentoring, faculty or group mentoring, and informal support of colleagues. Many worked responsively rather than according to one prescribed model.

Most mentors worked with approximately one to five individuals during the year. The most commonly reported time investment was 11–20 hours, although some mentors devoted more than 40 hours to the work. This illustrates both the potential and the demands of developing internal capacity. Training one experienced educator can extend support to several colleagues, but mentoring remains relational, high-touch work requiring real time.

Karen’s reflections identified the other side of this equation. Participants may leave a program with confidence and skill but still struggle to introduce new approaches into their schools. A single person can have difficulty influencing an established organizational culture, even when that person holds a leadership role.

Schools also need to recognize mentoring as actual professional work. A trained mentor cannot reasonably be expected to undertake substantial mentoring simply on top of a full teaching load. Schools may need to provide release time, recognize mentoring within FTE, offer a stipend, or make another structural adjustment.

Learning for institutes: Build implementation into professional development. Participants should leave asking not only “What have I learned?” but also “What needs to be in place in my school for me to use it successfully?” Programs intended to create institutional change might also encourage schools to send pairs or small teams rather than relying on one person to carry the learning back alone.

5. Build Professional Development Pathways Across the Career

One of the most significant findings from the survey is that mentoring was not confined to support for new teachers.

Mentors worked with new and untrained teachers, experienced Waldorf educators, people moving into new positions, special subject teachers, and pedagogical administrators.

For some participants, mentoring also became part of their own developing professional identity. The survey summary notes that participants sometimes experienced mentoring not simply as an additional responsibility but as an important dimension of who they were becoming professionally.

This connects with a larger observation from the facilitator interview. Many schools are rebuilding professional learning structures that were weakened during COVID. Professional development diminished, leadership and faculty changed, evaluation practices were interrupted, and some pedagogical meeting structures disappeared.

The need, therefore, is larger than mentor training. Schools need coherent ways to think about teacher development, mentoring, evaluation, pedagogical leadership, continued study, professional growth, and the development of experienced educators who are ready to support others.

Experienced and retired Waldorf educators may be an especially important resource. The program attracted seasoned educators—including retirees—who were interested in giving back to the movement.

Learning for institutes: Think in terms of professional development pathways rather than isolated courses. Institutes can help educators see how professional learning develops across a career while helping schools understand the structures needed to support that development. Mentoring can be one important element within that larger pathway.

6. Design for Access While Maintaining Meaningful Expectations

Several practical aspects of the program made participation more manageable.

The hybrid structure reduced travel. The in-person residency was scheduled when participants did not need substitutes or time away from their classrooms. An initially unintentional benefit of the January-to-November schedule was that program costs could fall across two school fiscal years, making participation easier for some schools to budget.

International participation was supported through scholarships and practical assistance with transportation and lodging.

At the same time, accessibility did not mean reducing expectations. Live participation in online sessions mattered, as did active engagement and appropriate attendance expectations for program completion.

The survey also provides useful evidence about the demands participants faced once trained. Mentoring commitments varied considerably, with some participants investing more than 40 hours over the year.

Learning for institutes: Accessibility should be considered broadly and from both the participant and school perspective. Tuition, scholarships, payment schedules, school budget cycles, travel, accommodation, time zones, substitute requirements, timing within the school year, and the time participants will need after the program to put their learning into practice all matter. Removing unnecessary barriers can coexist with maintaining high expectations for participation and professional engagement.

7. Collaborate Across Institutes—and Sustain Learning Beyond the Program

The mentoring initiative also generated useful learning about collaboration.

Early attempts to operate simultaneous residencies at more than one institute did not attract sufficient enrollment. Participants—including some traveling considerable distances—preferred to gather in the established New Hampshire location.

Rather than abandoning collaboration, the program found other ways to achieve it. Faculty from other teacher education institutes contributed to instruction, colleagues from other programs served as advisors and presenters, and international perspectives were incorporated into the learning.

This offers an important distinction for institutes: collaboration does not require duplication. Institutes can share instructors, expertise, resources, referrals, and learning without each creating its own version of every successful program.

The survey also reinforces the importance of sustaining learning after a formal program ends. Participants expressed interest in follow-up gatherings, artistic and pedagogical input, continued reflective spaces, and shared practical resources.

A Level II cohort was subsequently offered, with participants helping determine the content according to the issues they were encountering in their schools. Participants could also access individual guidance and remain connected with peers. Importantly, participants valued not only additional meetings but also practical shared resources, including collaboratively developed documents.

Learning for institutes: Follow-up can include alumni or advanced cohorts, peer networks, periodic in-person gatherings, consultation or office hours, shared resource libraries, collaboratively developed tools,

and pathways into additional professional learning. The end of a course does not need to be the end of the learning community.

Questions for Institutes to Consider

What current need in schools is this program addressing, and how do we know?

How will we gather information after participants have had an opportunity to apply their learning?

Are we designing a sustained learning journey or primarily delivering content?

Which experiences genuinely need to be in person, and which can work effectively online?

How are we building cohort relationships and professional community?

What practical tools will participants be able to use when they return to their schools?

What school structures, time, authority, or resources will be necessary for implementation?

Would participation by more than one person from a school increase the likelihood of lasting change?

How does this program connect to professional development across an educator's career?

What financial, scheduling, geographic, or logistical barriers can we reduce?

Where could collaboration with another institute strengthen the program without duplicating existing work?

What opportunities will participants have to continue learning, connecting, and sharing resources after the formal program ends?

Overall Implication

Taken together, the facilitator reflections and participant follow-up survey provide a fuller picture of the mentoring initiative. The survey suggests that participants left the program more confidently, used specific tools and frameworks in their mentoring, adapted their learning across a wide variety of roles and school settings, and generally felt well prepared for the work. The facilitator reflections help explain some of the conditions that supported those outcomes: an extended learning rhythm, a combination of online and in-person experiences, strong cohort relationships, practical and foundational content, consistent facilitation, opportunities for artistic and pedagogical work, and an ongoing willingness to adapt the program. They also identify where professional development alone is insufficient. Participants need schools that create the time and structures necessary to use what they have learned. Schools need coherent professional development pathways. And institutes need ways to remain connected to participants and to one another so that successful learning can continue to develop.

The larger opportunity is therefore not simply to create more courses.

It is to build an interconnected landscape of professional learning in which educators can continue developing throughout their careers, schools can strengthen their own internal capacity, and institutes can

collaborate around complementary strengths rather than duplicating one another’s work.

The mentoring initiative provides one useful source of learning for that larger task. Its value for other institutes lies not in reproducing the program, but in identifying what worked, testing those findings against participant experience, and applying the resulting lessons thoughtfully within different programs and contexts.

Sources: Facilitator interview with Karen Atkinson and the Mentor Training 2024 and 2025 Follow-up Surveys Disclosure: This report was written by a human being with the use of ChatGPT for identification of themes in the sources; comparisons between the different sources; and editing of the final report with human conclusions. Siân Owen-Cruise